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Campus extremism must be eradicated

MAX YONG, COMMENT

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When I started my master's degree at [Harvard University](#) this month, our orientation included a one-hour session on "safety and security". Topics included active shooter drills, door locking protocols, and building entry rules.

The campus has 24/7 security and requires a manned ID check-in every time you enter the building. This was a far cry from my [Melbourne University](#) orientation that included "beer-Olympics" and a campus tour that required no student identification at all.

A particularly telling moment was when I saw my American peers yawning as the university police captain discussed active shooter drills. They were as immune to this briefing as I am when the flight attendant shows me how to buckle my seatbelt.

And yes, the university has their own armed police force – something relatively common in the US.

Many Australians will isolate this – as well as Charlie Kirk's recent assassination – as something that is only possible in the "divided states" of America.

And while we have stronger controls around gun access and a slightly less toxic political debate, we cannot pretend that we are immune to political violence.

I don't mean to fearmonger, but there is a real threat of growing political violence and extremism in Australia. Some underlying polarisation is the flame, where social media – and all the "echo chamber" effects and disinformation it peddles – is the fuel. This is something that policymakers need to take seriously. Today.

Our own university campuses have recently seen more and more toxic debate. This is forcing vice-chancellors to contend with the line between "free speech" and "hate speech", or "right to protest" and "trespassing".

In the past year, Israel-Palestine tensions notably boiled up at many Australian universities, with student encampments that faced tense stand-offs with respective university administrations. [Western Sydney University](#) reported a case of "alleged assault" against campus security. Visiting speakers have faced vigorous protest as well. Ex-PM Malcolm Turnbull invoked claims of "fascism" after his speaking event at Sydney University was derailed by student protesters who characterised him as "ruling class scum".

I do believe universities tend to sit on the frontier of social debate in Australia, and I hope this continues to be the case. Moreover, I fully support the right to peaceful protest. However, any overt hate speech or violence should be immediately eradicated. It is worth noting that violence can take forms that are not only physical. A Nazi salute, for example, is an undeniably violent gesture.

In a world that seems to be post-unbiasedness, universities need to carefully think about ways to stamp out extremism.

The best leaders will find ways to maintain trust in their academic institutions while applying a no-tolerance approach to political violence. It is no small task, but as the heads of institutions who represent the frontier of knowledge in Australia they must be up for the challenge.

As the US announced tariffs on Australian goods, Albanese was quick to note that Australia are net importers from America.

Let's just make sure we don't import their growing tendency for political violence. Max Yong is an Australian education expert studying a master in public policy at [Harvard Kennedy School](#).

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